

STAGE EIGHT • SOFT SKILLS

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage Eight • Soft Skills

PURPOSE

Stage Eight runs across six sessions: Communication & Listening, Emotional Intelligence & Self-Awareness, Feedback & Conflict Resolution, Teamwork & Collaboration, Networking & Public Speaking, and Growth Mindset & Resilience. Each gets one icebreaker below, built directly from that session's actual content.

Because this stage is already interpersonally intensive, these openers lean toward quick, low-stakes group activities rather than individual writing prompts — they warm up the specific muscle (listening, emotional vocabulary, giving feedback, collaborating, speaking, honest reflection) each session is about to exercise more seriously.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

Six Openers, One Per Session

SESSION 1

The Telephone Test

TIME: 10 min

1. In a circle or small groups of 5-6, the first person whispers a two-sentence message to the next person, who whispers it to the next, and so on.
2. The last person says the message out loud. Compare it to the original.
3. Debrief quickly: what got lost or distorted, and why do you think that happened?

WHY THIS WORKS

A classic game, but genuinely relevant here: it makes the fragility of listening and message transmission visceral before the group tackles Active Listening (L1) and Listening for Understanding (L49).

SESSION 2

Name That Feeling

TIME: 8 min

1. Show the group 4-5 short, ambiguous scenario descriptions (facilitator-prepared, e.g., “your flight gets delayed six hours”).
2. For each, have participants silently write the single most accurate emotion word they can think of, not just “bad” or “frustrated.”
3. Compare answers across the group — notice the range of specific words for the same scenario.

WHY THIS WORKS

Primes the group for the emotional vocabulary work in Emotional Intelligence Practice (L29), showing early that generic labels miss real nuance most people are actually capable of naming.

SESSION 3

Compliment or Critique?

TIME: 8 min

1. Read the group 4-5 short sample feedback lines (facilitator-prepared: one vague positive, one vague negative, one specific and kind, one specific and harsh).
2. Quick show of hands: which one would you actually want to receive?
3. Brief discussion: what made the winning one different from the others?

WHY THIS WORKS

Sets up the entire session's focus on specific, constructive feedback before FIRSTS L5 and L6 ask participants to practice it directly.

SESSION 4

Build It Blind

TIME: 10 min

1. Small groups of 3–4. One person (the “builder”) is blindfolded or closes their eyes; the rest verbally guide them to build a simple structure with provided materials (cups, blocks, or even folded paper) without touching anything themselves.
2. After 3 minutes, reveal the result and debrief: what made instructions genuinely clear or confusing?

WHY THIS WORKS

A fast, physical demonstration of collaborative communication under real constraints, directly priming the structured collaboration exercises (L32, L18, L42) later in this session.

SESSION 5

60-Second Unprepared Talk

TIME: 10 min

1. Give each participant a random, low-stakes topic (facilitator-prepared slips: “why mornings are underrated,” “the best way to eat a sandwich”) and 60 seconds to speak on it with zero prep, in pairs or small groups.
2. No feedback needed — just the experience of speaking unprepared.
3. Quick debrief: how did it feel compared to a planned pitch?

WHY THIS WORKS

Lowers the stakes and the stigma of imperfect, unrehearsed speaking right before the session's more structured public speaking and networking work begins.

SESSION 6

One Word for This Stage

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask each participant to silently choose one word that captures their experience of Stage Eight so far.
2. Go around and share just the word, no explanation yet.
3. Notice any patterns or surprising outliers before moving into the day's reflective content.

WHY THIS WORKS

A light, fast way to surface real emotional temperature heading into the stage's closing, reflective session, without requiring anyone to over-explain before they're ready.